

Product Case Study Template

uTip (Easy Tipping app)

One-line case study headline:

Tipping can be a chore, let's make it simple.

My Role:

Product Strategy · UX · Design · Development

Product / Platform:

Mobile app/ Android

Timeline:

July 2025 – September 2025

Status:

Shipped

Case Study:

Retrospective analysis completed 2026

Focus Areas:

Discovery · Research · Problem Framing · Prioritization · MVP · Testing · Analytics

1. Executive Summary

What is this product?

uTip is a simple, ad-free Android app designed to make calculating a tip quick and easy without unnecessary features getting in the way.

What problem was I trying to solve?

I saw a simple task becoming more complicated than it needed to be. Many tipping experiences I encountered included ads, extra steps, or features I didn't need when all I wanted was to quickly calculate a tip and total.

The initial idea behind uTip was simple:

What if calculating a tip could just be fast, simple, and ad free?

What did I do?

I took the product from idea to a shipped Android application. I defined the initial experience, designed the interface, developed the app, and worked through the process of publishing it for real users.

After shipping it, I started looking at uTip differently, not just as something I built, but as a product I could learn from and improve through user feedback, research, and better product decision-making.

What changed?

The first version proved that I could take an idea all the way to a usable, shipped product.

Informal feedback has also reinforced one part of my original thinking: people appreciate how simple and distraction-free the experience is.

The next step is understanding **why**, where users still experience friction, and whether there are opportunities to improve the product without losing the simplicity that makes it useful.

Why does this case study matter?

This project demonstrates end-to-end product ownership: from identifying a problem and shipping an MVP to revisiting my assumptions through a Product Management lens.

More importantly, it represents a shift in how I approach building products:

From “Can I build this?” to “Should I build this, for whom, and how will I know it actually helped?”

2. Context

Where did this project start?

uTip started with a problem I experienced personally.

When it came time to calculate a tip, I either had to do the math myself or use apps and tools that often felt more complicated than the task required. Some included ads, extra screens, or features that I didn't care about.

I wanted something I could open, enter the bill, choose a tip, see the total, and move on.

So I built it.

What was the original assumption?

People who just want to calculate a tip quickly may value simplicity and an ad-free experience more than a large set of features.

What did I actually know?

At the beginning, I knew three things:

- I personally experienced friction with existing tipping options.
- I wanted a faster and simpler experience.
- I had the technical ability to build a mobile application that addressed that experience.

What I **didn't** know was whether my own frustration represented a meaningful problem for other people.

What didn't I know yet?

I had several major unknowns:

- Do other people experience the same frustration?
- What part of tipping actually causes the most friction?
- Is an ad-free experience important enough to matter?
- Which features do users actually value?
- Which features would add unnecessary complexity?
- Would people choose a dedicated tipping app instead of a calculator, browser search, or mental math?
- How should I measure whether the product is actually useful?

I also hadn't previously gone through the full process of taking this specific product from development through release and into the hands of real users.

3. The Problem

Initial problem statement

People who want to quickly calculate a tip can encounter unnecessary friction when the tools they use introduce ads, extra steps, or features they don't need, making a simple task feel more complicated than it should.

Why might this matter?

Tipping usually happens in a moment when someone wants an answer quickly.

A person may be finishing a meal, paying for a service, splitting a bill, or trying to decide on an appropriate amount while other people are waiting.

In those situations, even small amounts of friction can make a simple calculation feel unnecessarily frustrating.

The opportunity for uTip isn't necessarily to do **more**. It may be to do one thing exceptionally well.

It may be to help people accomplish one small task with as little friction as possible.

Evidence at this stage

At the beginning of the project, my evidence was limited.

The problem was primarily based on:

- my own experiences calculating tips;
- my experience with existing tipping tools;
- my observation that many alternatives included ads or additional complexity;
- early informal feedback from people who used uTip and commented positively on its simplicity.

However, I had not yet conducted structured user research, so I couldn't confidently say that my experience represented a broader user problem.

Status: Initial hypothesis — further validation needed.

4. What I Needed to Learn

Before deciding what to change next, I needed to understand whether my original assumptions matched how other people actually experience tipping.

I wanted to answer five questions:

1. **How do people currently calculate a tip when they need one?**
2. **What part of deciding or calculating a tip creates the most friction, if any?**
3. **How do people choose what percentage or amount to tip?**
4. **What matters most in a tipping tool: speed, simplicity, flexibility, guidance, or something else?**
5. **What would make someone choose a dedicated tipping app instead of using mental math, a calculator, or another tool?**

Biggest uncertainty

My biggest uncertainty was whether the problem I experienced was actually shared by other people.

I built uTip around the assumption that people would value a fast, simple, ad-free tipping experience. If research showed that most people were already satisfied with mental math, their phone calculator, or another existing method, then simply making a cleaner tip calculator might not create enough value on its own.

That finding would significantly change what I should prioritize next or whether the product needed additional features at all.

5. Research Plan

Research objective

The goal of my research is to understand **how people actually handle tipping today**, where friction or uncertainty appears in that process, and what, if anything, a product like uTip could do to make the experience meaningfully easier.

I am specifically looking to understand:

- current behaviors;
- moments of frustration or uncertainty;
- how people choose a tip amount;
- what tools they currently use;

- what they value in those tools;
- and whether uTip's simplicity and ad-free experience address a real need.

The goal is **not** to prove that uTip is a good idea. The goal is to learn whether the problem I assumed exists is actually worth solving.

Who I wanted to learn from

I want to speak with people who regularly encounter situations where tipping is expected, such as restaurants, bars, delivery services, rideshares, salons, and other service experiences.

Rather than only talking to people who already use tip calculator apps, I want participants with different habits, including people who:

- calculate tips mentally;
- use their phone's calculator;
- use Google or another tool;
- rely on suggested tip amounts;
- or already use dedicated tipping apps.

This gives me a better view of the **problem space**, instead of only studying people who already chose the same type of solution I built.

Method

I plan to use a combination of:

Semi-structured user interviews

Short conversations focused on recent real tipping experiences. I'll ask participants to describe what they actually did rather than asking what features they think they would want.

Lightweight usability testing

After understanding their current behavior, I'll ask some participants to complete a realistic tipping task using the current version of uTip.

I'll observe:

- where they hesitate;
- what they notice first;
- which controls they use or ignore;
- whether anything is confusing;
- and how quickly they can reach the answer they need.

Existing informal feedback

I can use previous comments from people who have already used uTip as supporting context, but I will keep that separate from the structured research because it was not collected through a consistent research process.

Participants

Completed: 3

6. Interview / Research Notes

Participant 1

Relevant context:

Frequently encounters tipping situations and usually relies on their spouse to decide or calculate the tip.

How they currently handle the problem:

They usually hand the tipping decision off to their spouse.

Pain points:

Tipping does not feel fast or simple to them. They described the process as a chore.

Behaviors I observed:

The participant appeared noticeably uncomfortable when discussing tipping and spoke about it with frustration.

Interesting quote:

“It’s not simple and I hate doing it.”

Something that surprised me:

The level of stress they associated with a task I had originally thought of as mostly a calculation problem.

Potential implication:

For this participant, the problem may be less about doing the math and more about reducing the mental effort and uncertainty involved in tipping. A simpler, more guided experience could be worth exploring.

Participant 2

Relevant context:

Frequently encounters tipping situations and usually uses their phone calculator to calculate the tip.

How they currently handle the problem:

They calculate the tip using their phone calculator, then try to adjust the amount so the final total rounds to a cleaner dollar amount.

Pain points:

They feel the process takes longer than it should, especially when they are trying to calculate the tip and round the total at the same time.

Behaviors I observed:

The participant described feeling rushed when calculating a tip, particularly when a server is waiting for them to finish.

Interesting quote:

“I just wish I could round up or down quicker.”

Something that surprised me:

Rounding the final total was not just a nice-to-have for this participant. It was part of how they naturally think about tipping.

Potential implication:

For this participant, speed and the ability to quickly reach a clean final total appear to be important. Reducing the number of calculations or steps required to round the total could make the experience feel less rushed.

Participant 3

Relevant context:

Frequently encounters tipping situations but dislikes spending time or mental effort deciding and calculating the tip.

How they currently handle the problem:

Rather than calculating an exact percentage, they often choose an even dollar amount that feels reasonable and write it down.

Pain points:

They dislike having to do mental math after a meal and want to finish the tipping process quickly.

Behaviors I observed:

The participant treated tipping as a task they wanted to get through with as little effort as possible rather than something they wanted to calculate precisely.

Interesting quote:

“I just write down a number half the time.”

Something that surprised me:

They were willing to sacrifice precision in order to avoid spending additional time or mental effort calculating an exact tip.

Potential implication:

For this participant, precision may matter less than speed and simplicity. This suggests there may be value in reducing the amount of calculation and decision-making required rather than simply providing more detailed tipping options.

7. Research Synthesis

After speaking with three participants, I started looking across the interviews for repeated behaviors rather than treating each response individually.

Because the sample is small, I consider these **early patterns rather than broad conclusions**.

Pattern 1 — Tipping feels like mental work

What I observed

All three participants described tipping as something that required more mental effort than they wanted to spend.

The source of that effort varied:

- Participant 1 described tipping as stressful and often handed the decision to their spouse.
- Participant 2 spent time calculating the tip and then adjusting it to reach a cleaner total.
- Participant 3 often avoided precise calculations altogether and chose an amount that simply felt reasonable.

Why it matters

My original assumption focused largely on the complexity of existing tipping tools.

These interviews suggest the friction may begin **before someone even opens a tool**. The act of deciding what to tip and calculating the final amount can itself feel like unnecessary work.

Pattern 2 — Speed matters more than precision for some people

What I observed

Participants repeatedly described wanting to finish the tipping process quickly.

Participant 2 felt rushed when a server was waiting and wanted a faster way to reach a rounded total. Participant 3 was willing to give up precise percentage calculations in exchange for finishing the task with less effort.

Why it matters

A useful tipping experience may not need to provide more information.

It may need to reduce the number of decisions and calculations required to reach a reasonable answer.

Pattern 3 — Rounding may represent a real behavior

What I observed

Participant 2 naturally adjusted their tip so the final total reached a cleaner dollar amount and specifically wished the process were faster.

Why it matters

uTip already includes Round Up and Round Down functionality.

This does not prove that rounding is important to every user, but it provides early evidence that the feature may support an existing behavior rather than simply being an extra feature I chose to build.

8. Assumptions vs. Evidence

Assumption 1

People will value a simple, ad-free tip calculator more than a feature-heavy experience.

What I found

Partially supported — but the reason may be different than I expected.

None of the three participants asked for more complexity. Instead, their comments consistently centered on wanting tipping to require less time, thought, or effort.

Evidence

One participant described tipping as a chore, another felt rushed during the calculation process, and another avoided precise calculations when possible.

Product implication

Simplicity still appears important, but my focus should not simply be:

“Remove features.”

The stronger opportunity may be:

Reduce the mental effort required to make and complete a tipping decision.

Assumption 2

The main problem is that existing tipping tools are too complicated.

What I found

Needs refinement.

The interviews suggest that the tool itself may only be one part of the problem.

Evidence

Participant 1 experienced stress around tipping generally, Participant 2 struggled with the time required to calculate and round the final amount, and Participant 3 often avoided calculation altogether.

Product implication

The problem may be broader than simplifying a calculator.

I should explore ways to make the **decision itself** feel faster and easier.

Assumption 3

Rounding is a useful convenience feature.

What I found

Early evidence supports this assumption for at least one participant.

Evidence

Participant 2 already tries to round their final amount manually and specifically described wanting a faster way to round up or down.

Product implication

Rather than treating rounding as a secondary feature, it may be worth testing whether making it more prominent helps users reach their desired total faster.

I would **not** call this validated yet because only one of the three participants specifically mentioned it.

9. Key Insights

Insight 1 — The friction may be decision effort, not just calculation

Insight:

The challenge may not simply be performing the math. Participants also described stress, time pressure, and a desire to avoid thinking about the calculation altogether.

Evidence:

Participant 1 often hands the task to their spouse, Participant 2 feels rushed while calculating, and Participant 3 sometimes chooses an arbitrary amount instead of calculating precisely.

Why it matters:

uTip may create more value by reducing decisions and mental effort rather than by simply being a cleaner calculator.

Insight 2 — Speed can be more valuable than precision

Insight:

For some participants, completing the tipping task quickly appeared more important than calculating an exact percentage.

Evidence:

Participant 2 described feeling rushed, while Participant 3 regularly chooses an approximate dollar amount instead of performing the calculation.

Why it matters:

Future improvements should be evaluated partly on whether they reduce time and effort—not simply whether they provide more control or information.

Insight 3 — Simplicity should reduce effort, not just remove features

Insight:

My original definition of simplicity focused on removing ads and unnecessary features. The

interviews suggest that true simplicity may also mean helping users make the tipping decision itself more easily.

Evidence:

Each participant described a different form of effort associated with tipping: stress, calculation time, or avoidance of mental math.

Why it matters:

The next version of uTip should not automatically add more features. I should first test whether I can make the existing experience require less thinking.

10. Refined Problem Statement

After research, rewrite the problem.

Before research

People who want to quickly calculate a tip can encounter unnecessary friction when the tools they use introduce ads, extra steps, or features they don't need, making a simple task feel more complicated than it should.

After research

People who want to complete a tip quickly may experience unnecessary mental effort when deciding, calculating, and adjusting the amount, especially when they feel rushed or simply want to finish the transaction.

What changed in my thinking?

I initially thought the primary problem was the **tip calculator itself**.

My assumption was that existing tools created friction through advertisements, unnecessary features, and extra complexity.

After speaking with three participants, I began to see a broader problem.

The participants were not only frustrated by how they calculated a tip. They described friction around the **entire decision**: deciding what amount feels right, doing the math, adjusting the final total, and completing the task while feeling rushed.

That changed the question I wanted to answer.

Instead of asking:

“How can I build a simpler tip calculator?”

I started asking:

“How can I reduce the effort it takes someone to decide on a tip and reach a final total?”

11. Product Opportunities

After reviewing the interviews, I wanted to turn the patterns I found into opportunities without immediately jumping to features.

Opportunity 1 — Reduce the effort required to choose a tip

Observation:

Participants described tipping as stressful, time-consuming, or something they wanted to finish with as little thought as possible. One participant even relied on their spouse to handle the decision, while another often chose an approximate amount rather than calculating an exact percentage.

User need:

A faster way to make a tipping decision without having to spend much time thinking or calculating.

Product opportunity:

Explore ways for uTip to help users reach a reasonable tip amount with fewer decisions and interactions.

Opportunity 2 — Make common tipping actions faster

Observation:

Participant 2 uses a calculator and then manually adjusts the amount to reach a cleaner final total. They specifically described wanting to round up or down more quickly.

User need:

A quick way to adjust a tip or final total without performing additional calculations.

Product opportunity:

Evaluate whether uTip's existing rounding functionality should be easier to notice and use.

Opportunity 3 — Protect simplicity as the product evolves

Observation:

None of the participants expressed a desire for a large number of additional features. Their frustrations were primarily related to effort, speed, and decision-making.

User need:

An experience that helps them finish the task quickly without introducing more complexity.

Product opportunity:

Improve the existing workflow before adding broader features such as bill splitting, detailed tipping guidance, or additional screens.

Opportunity statement

How might uTip reduce the amount of thought and effort required to move from a bill total to a completed tipping decision?

12. Solution Ideas

Once I understood the opportunities, I explored several possible ways to address them.

These ideas were not automatically treated as features to build. They were options to compare and test.

Idea 1 — Quick Tip Presets

Add clearly visible percentage options such as:

15% · 18% · 20% · 25%

instead of requiring the user to precisely adjust a percentage every time.

Addresses:

Decision effort and time spent calculating.

Potential user value:

High

Users could reach a common tip percentage with one tap.

Potential effort:

Low

This could likely be added without changing the fundamental structure of the application.

Confidence:

Medium

All three interviews suggest that reducing effort matters, but I have not yet tested whether percentage presets are the best way to achieve that.

Idea 2 — Make Round Up / Round Down More Prominent

Keep the existing rounding functionality but make it easier to discover and use.

Addresses:

The desire to reach a clean final total quickly.

Potential user value:

Medium

One participant specifically described this behavior.

Potential effort:

Low

The functionality already exists, so the main change would likely be presentation and interaction.

Confidence:

Low to Medium

There is direct evidence from one participant, but not enough yet to assume rounding is equally important to everyone.

Idea 3 — Remember the User's Previous Tip Percentage

Allow uTip to remember the percentage the user selected previously.

Addresses:

Repeated decision-making.

Potential user value:

Medium

It could make repeat usage faster for people who typically use the same percentage.

Potential effort:

Low

Confidence:

Low

None of the participants specifically asked for this behavior, so I would not prioritize it without additional evidence.

Idea 4 — Add More Advanced Tipping Features

Examples could include bill splitting, tipping recommendations, service categories, or more detailed calculations.

Potential user value:

Unknown

Potential effort:

Medium to High

Confidence:

Low

My current research does not provide evidence that these features solve the primary friction I observed.

For that reason, I would intentionally avoid expanding the product in this direction right now.

13. Prioritization

I compared the ideas based on the evidence I had, expected user value, implementation effort, and confidence.

Because this was a small qualitative study, I kept my confidence ratings conservative.

Opportunity / Idea	User Value	Effort	Confidence	Retrospective Decision
Quick Tip Presets	High	Low	Medium	Would test first
Improve Round Up / Down visibility	Medium	Low	Low–Medium	Would test next
Remember previous tip percentage	Medium	Low	Low	Would defer
Advanced features / more complexity	Unknown	Medium–High	Low	Would not pursue

What I prioritized

If development continued, the first idea I would test is **Quick Tip Presets**.

The strongest pattern across the interviews was not a demand for additional features. It was a desire to spend less time and mental effort completing the tipping task.

Allowing someone to select a common percentage with one tap could potentially address that friction without fundamentally changing the simplicity of uTip.

Why?

It gives me a relatively small change that can test a larger product hypothesis:

Will reducing the number of decisions and interactions make tipping feel noticeably easier?

This is better than trying to validate a large redesign all at once.

What I deliberately did NOT prioritize

I decided not to prioritize features such as bill splitting, detailed tipping recommendations, or additional calculation options.

Why not?

I currently have no research showing that those features address the primary problem uncovered in the interviews.

Adding them could also work against one of uTip's original strengths: keeping the experience simple.

The goal is not to make uTip capable of doing more. The goal is to make the job it already does easier.

14. Initial Product Decision

The decision

Test whether one-tap tip percentage presets can reduce the effort required to reach a desired tip while keeping the current experience simple.

I would explore adding common tip percentages such as:

15% · 18% · 20% · 25%

while preserving the ability to make more precise adjustments if needed.

User evidence

Across the three interviews, participants consistently described wanting to spend less effort on tipping, although they experienced that friction differently.

One participant described the process as stressful, another felt rushed while calculating, and another sometimes avoided precise calculations altogether.

Product rationale

A preset percentage could reduce the interaction from:

Decide percentage → adjust control → check calculation

to:

Choose percentage → see result

The change is intentionally small.

I want to first determine whether reducing interaction and decision effort improves the experience before introducing additional functionality.

Technical considerations

Because uTip already calculates the tip based on a selected percentage, adding preset percentage controls should reuse much of the existing calculation logic rather than requiring an entirely new product flow.

My technical background allows me to evaluate this as a relatively low-complexity experiment that can be tested before investing in a larger redesign.

Tradeoff

Adding visible preset controls introduces additional elements to an interface that was intentionally designed to be minimal.

The challenge is making common actions faster **without making the product feel more complicated**.

Therefore, the next step should be testing the proposed design rather than immediately shipping it.

15. Shipped Experience

Current Product

uTip currently focuses on completing one primary task: calculating a tip and final total quickly.

The current experience allows a user to:

- enter the bill amount;
- select a tip percentage;
- see the calculated tip;
- see the final total;
- round the amount up;
- or round the amount down.

The screenshot shows the uTip app interface. At the top is a green header with the text "uTip" and a back arrow icon. Below the header is a light purple rounded rectangle containing the input fields and calculations. The "Bill:" field has a text input with "\$78.45" and a blue underline. The "Tip:" field shows "\$15.69". The "Tip Percentage:" field features a horizontal slider with a black knob positioned at the 20% mark. Below these fields is a green rounded rectangle displaying "Total: \$94.14". At the bottom of the purple area are two green buttons: "Round up to nearest dollar" and "Round down to nearest dollar".

What works well

The current product is intentionally focused.

There are no advertisements, account creation requirements, or additional screens required to calculate a tip.

The core calculation is available immediately after opening the app.

Where friction may exist

My research suggests that although the app simplifies the calculation itself, there may still be unnecessary effort involved in **choosing the percentage and reaching the final amount someone wants.**

The existing percentage control gives users flexibility, but flexibility may not always be the same thing as speed.

That is what I would want to validate before making another product change.

Important distinction

Most of the current uTip experience was created **before I conducted structured user research.**

I don't want to present the existing features as if they were validated through the research process.

Instead, the interviews are helping me evaluate the product I already built and decide what should remain, what should change, and what I should avoid adding.

That distinction is important to this case study because it represents the biggest change in how I approached uTip:

The original version started with my solution. Revisiting it showed me why my next product should start with evidence.

16. What I Would Explore Next

Looking back at uTip through a Product Management lens, I would not immediately add more features.

The research suggests that the bigger opportunity may be reducing the amount of thought and effort required to complete a tipping decision.

If I continued developing uTip, I would explore three areas.

Opportunity 1 — Faster Tip Selection

I would explore whether common percentage presets such as:

15% · 18% · 20% · 25%

could help users reach a desired tip faster without removing the flexibility of the existing percentage control.

The goal would not be to add another feature simply because I could.

The question would be:

Can I reduce the number of decisions and interactions required to reach a tip?

Opportunity 2 — More Intentional Rounding

The shipped version already includes Round Up and Round Down functionality.

One participant specifically described manually adjusting their tip to reach a clean final total and wanting a faster way to do that.

If development continued, I would explore whether rounding should be more prominent or integrated more naturally into the main workflow.

Because only one participant specifically mentioned this behavior, I would want more evidence before making a significant change.

Opportunity 3 — Preserve Simplicity

I would also treat not adding features as a product decision.

Features such as bill splitting, detailed tipping recommendations, service categories, accounts, or more advanced calculations could make uTip capable of doing more.

But my research did not provide evidence that those features address the primary friction I observed.

Any future change would need to answer:

Does this make tipping easier, or does it simply make uTip bigger?

Protecting the simplicity of the experience would remain an important product constraint.

17. How I Would Validate It

If I continued developing uTip, I would test the strongest opportunity before committing to implementation.

My first experiment would focus on quick tip percentage presets.

Hypothesis

If users can select a common tip percentage with one tap, they will be able to complete the tipping task with less time and mental effort.

Prototype

I would create a lightweight prototype that introduces common percentage options while keeping the existing experience available.

For example:

15% · 18% · 20% · 25%

I would avoid rebuilding the entire application before learning whether the change actually helps.

Usability test

I would ask participants to complete a realistic task such as:

“Your bill is \$78.45 and you want to leave a 20% tip. Show me how you would complete the tip.”

I would test both the current experience and the proposed experience.

What I would observe

I would look for:

- how quickly participants reach the desired amount;
- how many interactions are required;
- where participants hesitate;
- whether the preset percentages are immediately understood;
- whether participants still want the existing percentage control;
- whether the new controls make the interface feel easier or more cluttered.

What would change my mind?

If users ignored the presets, found them unnecessary, or felt that they made the interface more complicated, I would not ship the change simply because it seemed like a good idea.

The purpose of the test would be to reduce uncertainty before investing further.

18. Measuring Success

Because I did not define formal success metrics when I originally shipped uTip, I would approach measurement differently if I continued the product today.

Rather than measuring how many features were added, I would focus on whether users can complete the core task more easily.

Primary success signal

Time to complete a tip

Why it matters:

The strongest pattern from my interviews was a desire to reduce the time and effort associated with tipping.

If a change allows someone to reach their desired tip and total faster, that would provide evidence that the experience is improving.

Supporting signal — Task completion

I would measure whether participants can successfully calculate their desired tip and total without assistance.

Why it matters:

A fast experience is not valuable if users are confused or cannot complete the task correctly.

Supporting signal — Interaction effort

I would compare the number of taps or adjustments required to complete the same task.

Why it matters:

Reducing unnecessary interaction could help lower the mental effort associated with the process.

Qualitative signal — Perceived ease

After completing the task, I would ask participants questions such as:

“How easy or difficult did that feel?”

and:

“Was there anything you had to think about more than you expected?”

Why it matters:

The interviews showed that some of the friction around tipping is emotional or cognitive, not just mathematical.

Important distinction

These are proposed success measures, not results from the current shipped version.

One of my biggest takeaways from revisiting uTip is that success criteria should be defined before making the next product change.

19. Outcomes of the Shipped Product

uTip reached one important outcome:

It became a real, shipped product rather than remaining an idea or prototype.

I took the application from concept through design, development, testing, and release on Android.

The shipped product delivers the core experience I originally set out to create:

- an ad-free tipping experience;
- a focused interface;
- tip percentage adjustment;
- immediate tip and total calculations;
- Round Up and Round Down controls;
- no unnecessary accounts or additional screens.

User feedback

Informal feedback from people who have used uTip has been positive around the product's simplicity and lack of distractions.

However, this feedback was not collected through a structured research process, so I do not treat it as strong evidence of broader product success.

What I cannot claim

I did not establish formal success metrics before launch, and I do not have enough evidence to make claims about:

- retention;
- increased user satisfaction;
- time saved;
- conversion;
- long-term usage;
- or broader market demand.

That is an important limitation of the original project.

Why the outcome still matters

Shipping uTip gave me something more valuable than a theoretical product exercise.

It gave me a real product that I could look back on critically and ask:

What did I assume? What did I actually know? What should I have validated before building? And how would I approach the same problem differently today?

That reflection became one of the most valuable outcomes of the project.

20. What I Learned

Revisiting uTip changed the way I think about building products.

Lesson 1 — My experience is a starting point, not evidence

uTip originally started because I personally experienced frustration with tipping tools.

That was enough to generate an idea.

It was not enough to prove that I understood the broader user problem.

Talking with other people showed me that their frustrations were not identical to mine.

Some experienced stress around deciding what to tip. Others felt rushed doing the calculation. Another participant cared less about precision and more about simply finishing the task.

A personal problem can inspire a product idea, but research is what helps determine whether that problem extends beyond me.

Lesson 2 — Building the solution does not mean I understand the problem

My original mindset was largely:

“I see a problem and I know how to build something that solves it.”

Today, I would spend more time asking:

“What exactly is the problem?”

“Who experiences it?”

“How are they solving it today?”

“Which part is actually worth improving?”

The difference sounds small, but it changes when and why I decide to build.

Lesson 3 — Simplicity is more than removing features

I originally thought simplicity meant:

no ads + fewer screens + fewer features.

The interviews made me think about simplicity differently.

A product can have very few features and still require too much thought from the user.

For uTip, simplicity may also mean reducing:

- decisions;
- calculations;

- interactions;
- uncertainty;
- and time pressure.

The goal is not simply to make the interface smaller. It is to make the user's job easier.

Lesson 4 — Saying “not yet” is part of Product Management

It would be easy to continue adding features to uTip.

Bill splitting, suggested tips, service categories, accounts, history, and many other additions are technically possible.

But possibility is not evidence of value.

The research gave me no reason to believe that adding more functionality was the most important next step.

I learned that Product Management is as much about deciding what not to build as deciding what to build.

Lesson 5 — Define success before shipping

When I originally built uTip, success largely meant:

Does the app work, and can I ship it?

Today, I would define success around the user outcome before implementation.

For example:

- **Can users complete the task faster?**
- **Do they need fewer interactions?**
- **Do they experience less uncertainty?**
- **Are they able to complete the task without assistance?**

Without those measures, a shipped feature proves that something was built—not necessarily that something improved.

My biggest takeaway

If I approached uTip again today, I would still build something simple.

But I would change the order.

Instead of:

Idea → Build → Ship → Learn

I would approach it as:

Problem → Evidence → Opportunity → Decision → Test → Build → Measure → Learn

uTip originally proved that I could take an idea and turn it into a real product.

Revisiting it taught me something more important:

Building the product is only part of Product Management. The real work is understanding what deserves to be built and why.

21. What I Would Do Differently

Looking back, the biggest change I would make is **when I started learning from users**.

When I originally built uTip, I moved quickly from my own frustration to a solution. I knew the type of experience I wanted, and because I had the technical ability to build it, I went straight into designing and developing the app.

If I approached the same project today, I would change that order.

Start with discovery

Before designing the first version, I would talk with people who regularly encounter tipping situations and understand:

- how they currently decide what to tip;
- what tools they use;

- where they experience friction;
- what they already do to make the process easier;
- and whether the problem is significant enough to justify a dedicated product.

This would help me distinguish between:

a problem I personally experience

and

a problem worth solving for a broader group of users.

Define the problem before defining the features

Originally, I entered the project already thinking about what the application should do.

Today, I would first define:

Who is experiencing the problem?

What job are they trying to accomplish?

Where does that experience break down?

What evidence supports that conclusion?

Only then would I decide which product capabilities make sense.

Define success before launch

I would also establish clear success signals before building.

Instead of defining success as:

“The application works and is available to users.”

I would define the user outcome I want to improve and decide how I will measure it.

For uTip, that could include:

- how quickly someone completes a tipping task;
- whether they can complete it without assistance;

- how many interactions it requires;
- and how easy the experience feels.

Test before investing heavily in development

Because I can build software myself, there is a temptation to solve uncertainty by writing code.

Today, I would use lower-cost methods first.

A simple prototype and several usability tests could answer important questions before committing time to development.

My technical ability helps me build quickly. Product thinking helps me decide when building is actually the right next step.

22. What's Next for Me

I do not currently plan to continue developing uTip.

Instead, I see the project as an important step in how my approach to Product Management has evolved.

uTip started as a project focused primarily on building and shipping.

Revisiting it gave me an opportunity to practice:

- identifying assumptions;
- conducting user interviews;
- separating evidence from interpretation;
- synthesizing patterns;
- reframing a problem;
- identifying product opportunities;
- prioritizing based on evidence;
- and thinking about how success should be measured.

Applying the lesson forward

The biggest value of this case study is not the list of features I could add to uTip.

It is how the experience will influence the next product problem I work on.

For future projects, I want to start earlier with:

Who is the user?

What problem are they actually experiencing?

What evidence do I have?

What is the smallest thing I can test before committing to a solution?

uTip helped me move from thinking primarily like a builder toward thinking more intentionally about **why something should be built in the first place.**

23. Final Reflection

When I first created uTip, I was proud that I could take an idea, design it, build it, and ship it.

I still am.

But revisiting the project showed me that shipping is only one part of creating a good product.

The more valuable questions are:

Did I understand the problem?

Did I understand the user?

Did I make the right tradeoffs?

Did the solution actually improve something?

And:

How do I know?

The original version of uTip gave me experience building a product.

The retrospective gave me experience questioning my own assumptions about that product.

That shift—from defending my solution to being willing to challenge it—is one of the biggest lessons I’m taking forward as a Product Manager.

24. Recruiter Summary

The Problem

Tipping is a simple task that can still create unnecessary mental effort, time pressure, and uncertainty for people trying to quickly complete a transaction.

The Evidence

I revisited the assumptions behind uTip by conducting three qualitative user interviews. Participants described different forms of friction, including stress around making the tipping decision, time spent calculating and rounding, and avoiding precise calculations altogether.

The Insight

The problem was broader than I originally assumed.

My initial focus was on creating a simpler tip calculator. The research suggested that the more meaningful opportunity may be reducing the **mental effort involved in the tipping decision itself**.

The Decision

Rather than assuming the answer was adding more functionality, I identified several potential opportunities and prioritized a small experiment around making common tipping decisions faster while intentionally deprioritizing unsupported feature expansion.

The Outcome

uTip shipped as a real Android application, but the retrospective also exposed limitations in my original process, particularly the lack of structured discovery and predefined success metrics.

What this demonstrates about me as a Product Manager

This project demonstrates my ability to look critically at something I built, challenge my own assumptions, gather user evidence, refine the problem, identify opportunities, make tradeoffs, and separate what I **know** from what I merely **believe**.

Most importantly, it changed the question I ask when approaching a product:

Not just “Can I build this?” but “Should I build this, for whom, and how will I know it helped?”